

# Xueqi Cheng

Ph.D. Student in Computer Science · Florida State University

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## BIOGRAPHY

Xueqi Cheng is a Ph.D. student in Computer Science at Florida State University, advised by Dr. Yushun Dong, and a member of the Responsible AI (RAI) Lab. His current research interests include agentic AI (e.g., agent distillation and model routing), LLM compression (e.g., knowledge distillation, pruning, and quantization), and multimodal models. He is also interested in AI for social good and real-world applications of AI, including social network analysis and civil and infrastructure engineering.

## EDUCATION

### Florida State University

*Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.) in Computer Science*

2025 – present

- Advisor: Dr. Yushun Dong, Responsible AI (RAI) Lab

### Vanderbilt University

*Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.) in Computer Science (transferred out)*

2023 – 2025

- Advisor: Dr. Tyler Derr, Network and Data Science (NDS) Lab

*Master of Science (M.S.) in Systems Engineering*

2021 – 2023

## RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

### Applied Research, Nokia of America Corporation

*Research Intern*

May 2026 – present

- Research topic: Agent distillation
- Manager: Kelly Wan; Mentor: Dr. Liang Wu

### Responsible AI Lab, Florida State University

*Ph.D. Student*

Aug 2025 – present

- Research areas: Agentic AI, LLM compression, multimodal models
- Advisor: Dr. Yushun Dong

### Chief Data Office, AT&T Labs

*Research Intern*

Jun 2025 – Aug 2025

- Research topic: Efficient LLM serving for multi-turn dialogues
- Manager: Dr. Divesh Srivastava; Mentors: Dr. Qiong Wu, Dr. Zhengyi Zhou

### Network and Data Science Lab, Vanderbilt University

*Ph.D. Student*

Aug 2023 – May 2025

- Research areas: Geometric deep learning, social network analysis, AI for social good
- Advisor: Dr. Tyler Derr

## SCHOLARSHIPS & AWARDS

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|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| • Osher Lifelong Learning Institute Scholarship, Florida State University  | Apr 2026 |
| • WSDM NSF Travel Award                                                    | Feb 2026 |
| • CS Student Seminar Best Presentation Runner-Up, Florida State University | Nov 2025 |
| • Naaman Franklin Faile Jr. Graduate Fellowship, Florida State University  | Sep 2025 |
| • Engineering Graduate Fellowship, Vanderbilt University                   | Aug 2023 |
| • IBM PhD Fellowship, Vanderbilt University                                | Aug 2021 |

## PUBLICATIONS

### Conference Papers

\* Equal contribution (co-first authors)

- [C04] **LatentRouter: Can We Choose the Right Multimodal Large Language Model Before Seeing Its Answer?**  
Xueqi Cheng, Yushun Dong  
*Proceedings of the 40th Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS), 2026*    Acceptance rate 25.7%

- [C03] **BTS: A Comprehensive Benchmark for Tie Strength Prediction**  
 Xueqi Cheng, Catherine Yang, Yuying Zhao, Yu Wang, Hamid Karimi, Tyler Derr  
*Proceedings of the 31st ACM SIGKDD Conference on Knowledge Discovery and Data Mining (KDD)*, 2025  
 Oral · Acceptance rate 22%
- [C02] **Edge Classification on Graphs: New Directions in Topological Imbalance**  
 Xueqi Cheng\*, Yu Wang\*, Yunchao (Lance) Liu, Yuying Zhao, Charu C. Aggarwal, Tyler Derr  
*Proceedings of the 18th ACM International Conference on Web Search and Data Mining (WSDM)*, 2025  
 Acceptance rate 17.3%
- [C01] **A Topological Perspective on Demystifying GNN-based Link Prediction Performance**  
 Yu Wang, Tong Zhao, Yuying Zhao, Yunchao Liu, Xueqi Cheng, Neil Shah, Tyler Derr  
*Proceedings of the 12th International Conference on Learning Representations (ICLR)*, 2024  
 Acceptance rate 31%

### Journal Papers

- [J03] **Towards Trustworthy Retrieval Augmented Generation for Large Language Models: A Survey**  
 Bo Ni, Zheyuan Liu, Leyao Wang, Yongjia Lei, Yuying Zhao, Xueqi Cheng, Qingkai Zeng, Luna Dong, Yinglong Xia, Krishnaram Kenthapadi, Ryan Rossi, Franck Dernoncourt, Md Mehrab Tanjim, Nesreen Ahmed, Xiaorui Liu, Wenqi Fan, Erik Blasch, Yu Wang, Meng Jiang, Tyler Derr  
*ACM Computing Surveys (CSUR)*, 58(15), 2026
- [J02] **A Survey on Privacy in Graph Neural Networks: Attacks, Preservation, and Applications**  
 Yi Zhang, Yuying Zhao, Zhaoqing Li, Xueqi Cheng, Yu Wang, Olivera Kotevska, Philip S. Yu, Tyler Derr  
*IEEE Transactions on Knowledge and Data Engineering (TKDE)*, 36(12), 2024  
 Impact factor 8.9
- [J01] **Fairness and Diversity in Recommender Systems: A Survey**  
 Yuying Zhao, Yu Wang, Yunchao Liu, Xueqi Cheng, Charu Aggarwal, Tyler Derr  
*ACM Transactions on Intelligent Systems and Technology (TIST)*, 16(1), 2025  
 Impact factor 7.2

### Workshop and Symposium Papers

- [W02] **Edge-centric Network Analytics**  
 Xueqi Cheng  
*Proceedings of the 18th ACM International Conference on Web Search and Data Mining (WSDM) Doctoral Consortium*, 2025
- [W01] **Urban Bridge Conceptual Design Based on Virtual Reality Graphic Engine**  
 Xueqi Cheng, Yan Zhang, Sining Lu, Yinqiao Zhu, Wei He  
*IABSE Symposium Report, International Association for Bridge and Structural Engineering (IABSE)*, 2017

### Preprints

- [P06] **Adverse Online Social Interactions: A Multi-Level Evolutionary Analysis of Local Patterns, Diffusion, and Community Disruption**  
 Xueqi Cheng\*, Qinwen Ge\*, Hamid Karimi, Yushun Dong, Tyler Derr  
*arXiv preprint arXiv:2606.20846*, 2026
- [P05] **A Nationwide Benchmark for Wildfire Initial Attack Failure Prediction with Public Environmental Data**  
 Runyang Xu\*, Xueqi Cheng\*, Yushun Dong  
*arXiv preprint arXiv:2606.15529*, 2026
- [P04] **SOMA: Efficient Multi-turn LLM Serving via Small Language Model**  
 Xueqi Cheng, Qiong Wu, Zhengyi Zhou, Xugui Zhou, Tyler Derr, Yushun Dong  
*arXiv preprint arXiv:2605.11317*, 2026
- [P03] **ReAD: Reinforcement-Guided Capability Distillation for Large Language Models**  
 Xueqi Cheng, Xugui Zhou, Tyler Derr, Yushun Dong  
*arXiv preprint arXiv:2605.11290*, 2026
- [P02] **MISLEADER: Defending against Model Extraction with Ensembles of Distilled Models**  
 Xueqi Cheng, Minxing Zheng, Shixiang Zhu, Yushun Dong  
*arXiv preprint arXiv:2506.02362*, 2025
- [P01] **Amplifying Your Social Media Presence: Personalized Influential Content Generation with LLMs**  
 Yuying Zhao, Yu Wang, Xueqi Cheng, Anne Marie Tumlin, Yunchao Liu, Damin Xia, Meng Jiang, Tyler Derr  
*arXiv preprint arXiv:2505.01698*, 2025

## OPEN-SOURCE PROJECTS

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### PyHazards

Jan 2026

A Python framework for AI-powered hazard prediction and risk assessment. It provides a hazard-first API for loading data, building models, running end-to-end experiments, and extending with your own modules.

## TALKS

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### Industry Presentations

[I02] **Efficient Context-dependent Multi-turn LLM Serving** Aug 2025  
AT&T Labs

[I01] **Predicting and Interpreting Churn Risks for Broadband Customers** Jul 2025  
AT&T Labs

### Guest Lectures

[L01] **Introduction to Python/PyG** Oct 2023  
CS 4352/5352: Social Network Analysis, Department of Computer Science, Vanderbilt University

## TEACHING EXPERIENCE

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### Vanderbilt University, Department of Computer Science

#### Teaching Assistant

Aug 2023 – May 2025

- CS 4352/5352: Social Network Analysis
- CS 4260: Introduction to Artificial Intelligence
- CS 5892: Project in Data-Centric AI

### Vanderbilt University, Department of Civil and Environmental Engineering

#### Teaching Assistant

Aug 2021 – May 2023

- CE 2200: Statics
- CE 3205: Structural Design
- CE 3200: Structural Analysis

## MENTORING

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### Responsible AI Lab, Florida State University

- Hugh Long, M.S. Computer Science Fall 2025 – present  
Research topic: Wildfire prediction visualization
- Runyang Xu, B.S. Statistics Fall 2025 – present  
Research topic: Wildfire prediction foundation models; next position: M.S. Statistics, University of Michigan, Ann Arbor

### Network and Data Science Lab, Vanderbilt University

- Qinwen Ge, Ph.D. Computer Science Spring 2025 – Spring 2026  
Research topic: Social network analysis
- Bo Ni, Ph.D. Computer Science Spring 2024 – Spring 2025  
Research topic: Trustworthy retrieval-augmented generation
- Catherine Yang, M.S. Computer Science Fall 2024 – Spring 2025  
Research topic: Social network analysis; next position: Software Engineer, Microsoft

## SERVICES

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- **Organizing:** Publicity Chair, the 5th International Workshop on Machine Learning on Graphs (MLog) at WSDM'24
- **Conference Reviewer / PC Member:** NeurIPS, ICML, KDD, ICWSM, WSDM, AAAI, WWW, SDM, IEEE Big Data, CIKM
- **Journal Reviewer:** Pattern Recognition, ACM Transactions on Knowledge Discovery from Data (TKDD)